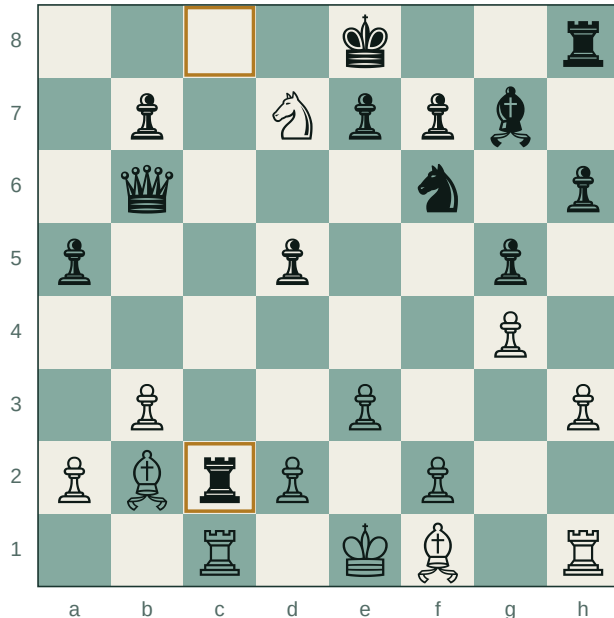


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 16

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 15...Rxc2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16. Nxb6 Rxc1+ 17. Bxc1

16.Nxb6 The knight captures the queen on b6. Recorded reply: **16...Rxc1+**.

17.Bxc1 The bishop captures the rook on c1.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -6 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on g7 and queen on b6. Check for tactical protection.